Montagu explained to Chelmsford, compliance with this demand was to be viewed as evidence of Afghan good faith towards Britain.[77]

The problem, however, lay with the idea that the British government was in a position to make such a demand of the Afghan government in the first place. While there were certainly advantages for Kabul in gaining a treaty of friendship with Britain, Afghanistan was by no means in a position of desperation. Not only did it now have Soviet Russia as an ally and potential source of funds and military supplies, but it was also busy making friends with the likes of Turkey and Persia; a Turko-Afghan treaty being concluded on 1 March 1921, followed in June by an agreement with Tehran.[78] Afghanistan also had less to fear from India following the First World War. The Afghan government could be relatively certain that the current weakness of its military meant the Indian government would only use force against its neighbour if extremely provoked. The ability to incite the tribes on India's borders to unrest against the Indian government was also a crucial advantage to Afghanistan. And, as the Afghan delegation pointed out to Dobbs, it was also aware that 'almost the whole world [is] hostile to Great Britain. All Musalmans are against you over the Khilafat question. You are in trouble in India.'[79]

Thus, Afghanistan could have confidence when it was negotiating with India in 1921:

All the Islamic world looks to us and considers us the leaders of Islam. We shall be taking a great burden on ourselves if we make friendship with you, and must have a substantial quid pro quo which will satisfy our people. You are in great need of our friendship, for if you make friends with us, India will turn towards you.[80]

Naturally, Dobbs tried to disabuse the Afghans of this belief by arguing that 'Afghanistan needs British friendship far more than Great Britain needs hers. You are a small country between two big Powers. You have to be very careful.'[81] Such public bravado between the two delegations was inevitable.